The world's radical Islamic organizations, such as al-Qaeda and ISIS, have confronted the Western democracies with a variable that did not exist during the time of the conventional wars or during the era of classical terrorism. These terrorist organizations are amorphous, without headquarters or a clear hierarchy, and their virtual deployment is global. Their means of communication is the internet, through which they communicate with their members, coconspirators, supporters, and adherents from around the world. They use the internet to spread their message through their propaganda networks, as well as to recruit, to train, and to produce various types of weapons. Since without holding at least a minimal amount of territory they cannot exist, they are constantly looking for areas to live— places where there is political instability or where they can find allies. These could be, for example, the Palestinian territories, from which the Palestinian terrorist organizations operate, or areas in southern Lebanon that have been taken over by Hezbollah, to the chagrin of the Lebanese government but with the support of Syria and Iran. They could include Sudan, where bin Laden found an ally in Hassan al-Turabi, who provided bin Laden and his people with a territorial base from which to operate not only out of sympathy but also in exchange for financial payment. They could include Afghanistan, where bin Laden essentially bought the Taliban government that was in control, with part of the deal being the right of residence and a base for al-Qaeda operations. And they could span the entire planet, throughout which the members of the organizations and their infrastructure are scattered, as is the case today, following the US military operations in Afghanistan after 9/11.

The policy of the Israeli government has always been that the countries from which the terrorists operate bear the burden of responsibility, as they do not prevent the terrorist organizations from using their territory. Israel therefore sees as its right to fight the terrorist organizations in the territory of the countries that harbor them. More than once, the Israeli government has been condemned for this policy by the enlightened nations of the world. The American war against al-Qaeda around the world reflected a policy similar to that of Israel, as did the CIA's targeting of a car carrying al-Qaeda commanders in Yemen, not to mention the dozens of operations aimed at thwarting radical Islamic activity that have been carried out throughout the world.